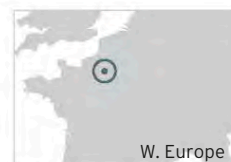




Arc de Triomphe

A monumental arch, a symbol of French patriotism, located in the heart of Paris



△ FOCAL POINT

The current prominence of the arch owes much to the work of Baron Haussmann, who redesigned the *Place de l'Étoile* completely as part of his radical transformation of Paris in 1853-1870.

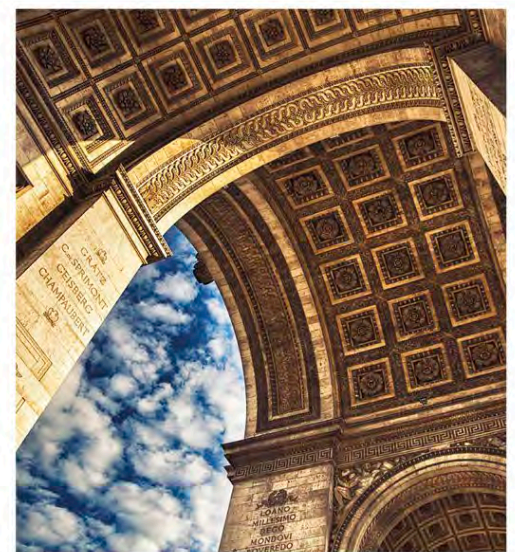
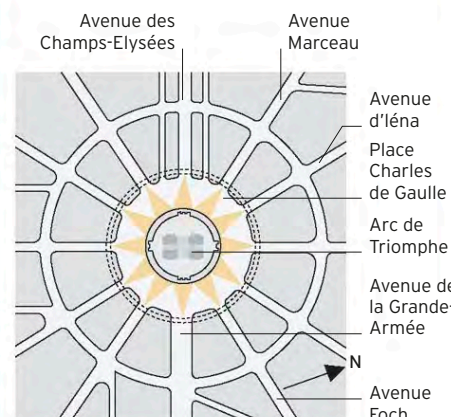
Built between 1806 and 1836, the Arc de Triomphe is an imposing legacy of the Napoleonic era, commissioned by Bonaparte himself to celebrate his victory at the Battle of Austerlitz (1805). He never lived to see it, although his cortège passed through it when his body was returned to France in 1840.

National significance

Designed by Jean-François Chalgrin, the arch is 164 ft (50 m) high, affording spectacular views of the city from its summit. The design is loosely based on a Roman triumphal arch, and the monument is dedicated to France's military achievements. On the exterior are beautifully sculpted panels and a frieze commemorating famous victories, while the names of distinguished officers are listed on the inner walls. The Tomb of the Unknown Soldier lies underneath the arch, with an eternal flame that is rekindled every day. The Arc de Triomphe has become the nation's focal point during times of celebration, as well as mourning. It is also the traditional starting point for the annual Bastille Day parade.

PLACE DE L'ETOILE

The arch is situated prominently on a roundabout where 12 avenues converge. The road layout is symmetrical, forming the shape of a star and giving rise to the name *Place de l'Étoile* ("place of the star"), but the name changed to Place Charles de Gaulle in 1970.



△ INNER WALLS

The names of 660 military commanders—most dating back to the Napoleonic era—are inscribed on the internal walls of the arch.